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Undergraduate Dissertation

Trabajo Fin de Grado

“You Are Not the Contents of Your Wallet”:
Narrative Structure, Alienation and Capitalism in
Fight Club (1999).

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ABSTRACT

This dissertation examines the narrative structure of *Fight Club* (David Fincher, 1999) and its thematic critique of consumerism and capitalism. Through an analysis grounded in the conventions of puzzle films, this essay explores how the film's fragmented storytelling—anchored by an unreliable narrator—reflects the protagonist's psychological disintegration and social alienation. Drawing on theories of narration and identity, the study analyses how the *fabula* and *syuzhet* manipulate audience perception, leading to a final narrative reversal that reconfigures the film's ideological implications. The essay also explores the duality between Jack (Edward Norton) and Tyler (Brad Pitt) as contrasting embodiments of modern masculinity, highlighting how their conflict serves as a metaphor for the struggle against capitalist conformity and the crisis of male identity in a consumer-driven society. Ultimately, the film's complex narrative structure is shown to parallel its thematic concerns, positioning *Fight Club* as both a psychological puzzle and a cultural critique.

Key words: alienation - capitalism - consumerism - identity - narrative structure.

RESUMEN

Este Trabajo de Fin de Grado examina la estructura narrativa de *Fight Club* (David Fincher, 1999) y su crítica al consumismo y al capitalismo. A través de un análisis basado en las convenciones del *puzzle film*, el trabajo explora cómo su narración fragmentada—caracterizada por un narrador no fiable—refleja la desintegración psicológica y alienación social del protagonista. Utilizando teorías de narración e identidad, el trabajo analiza cómo la *fábula* y el *syuzhet* manipulan la percepción del espectador, conduciendo a un vuelco narrativo que reconfigura las implicaciones ideológicas de la película. El trabajo también explora la dualidad existente entre los

personajes de Jack (Edward Norton) y Tyler (Brad Pitt), que reflejan el contraste entre dos tipos de masculinidad moderna. Se argumenta que este conflicto funciona como metáfora de la lucha contra la conformidad capitalista y la crisis de identidad masculina en una sociedad basada en el consumismo. La compleja estructura narrativa de *Fight Club* refleja así sus preocupaciones temáticas, posicionando la película como rompecabezas psicológico y crítica cultural al mismo tiempo.

Palabras clave: alienación - capitalismo - consumismo - identidad - estructura narrativa

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1. INTRODUCTION

Fight Club is a film directed by David Fincher released in 1999. The film is an adaptation of a novel of the same name by Chuck Palahniuk published in 1996. The movie, which is a mixture of several genres, can be mainly described as a psychological thriller and a puzzle film. *Fight Club* tells the story of a nameless man with insomnia played by Edward Norton. He is the protagonist and the film's internal narrator. He is unhappy with his job (he is a recall coordinator) and leads a life ruled by consumerism. As a result of his alienation not only as a man but also as a human being, he aims for a change. The change materializes in the creation of an underground club in which the members fight between them. Tyler Durden (Brad Pitt) is the charismatic leader of the club. The club becomes a violent movement against social rules and capitalism and its members, including the protagonist, are recruited into Project Mayhem, which is Tyler's violent plan to destroy the social norms that, according to Tyler, are emasculating and alienating men.

When the film was released, critics had mixed reactions to the film. Scott Tobias (2019), writing for *The Guardian*, praised the film because of its "thrilling vividness and wit and technical panache" in anticipating the rise of the toxic masculinity and radicalised consequences, concluding that "*Fight Club* saw it coming." For example, the incel culture is a contemporary movement in which men blame society and women because of their social and sexual rejection. Matt Miller (2019) from *Esquire* criticised the film's ideology: "*Fight Club* popularized a version of toxic machismo that has been co-opted by online trolls and the alt-right. It's a film guilty of horrible misogyny. Worst of all, it doesn't even do a very good job tackling its central theme of mass consumerism." There were mixed reactions among critics. Some of them disliked the film's display of violence. Bradshaw (2024) labelled the

film's violence as "unreal and consequence-free." He also criticises the film's ending, which he considers an "ungainly and disappointing twist."

This essay reads the narrative structure of the film, especially the way in which its puzzle film conventions lead spectators to draw false assumptions from the very beginning. It starts with a section on the category puzzle films, as described by Buckland (2009), linking them to other examples such as *Shutter Island* and *The Sixth Sense*. After this introduction, the analysis of the film starts with a description of its fabula and syuzhet, paying attention to how the syuzhet manipulates the fabula with a specific aim in mind. The second part of the analysis explores issues such as masculinity, identity and alienation in the movie, also addressing broader social issues such as capitalism and consumerism. As this essay argues, the narrative structure of the movie can be linked to broader thematic issues such as the alienation of the individual caused by consumer and capitalist culture.

2. PUZZLE FILMS

Fight Club is a contemporary puzzle film. According to Buckland (2009), these types of films belong to “a popular cycle of films from the 1990s that rejects classical storytelling techniques and replaces them with complex storytelling” (p. 1). The classical Hollywood storytelling is characterised by having a clear narrative structure. It usually follows the three-act structure (set-up, confrontation and resolution) that Syd Field and others trace back to Aristotle (2005, p. 3). It usually presents the events in a chronological order. In addition to this, the classical Hollywood narrative follows a clear cause-and-effect structure in which characters’ actions drive the plot forward. Each scene leads logically to the next, although it may distract the audience, it eventually leads to a coherent conclusion (Bordwell, 2008).

In the introduction to his book *Puzzle Films*, Buckland distinguishes between two types of plots in contemporary films: simple and complex (2009, pp. 1-12). Simple plots, according to Buckland, follow the classical Hollywood storytelling pattern which the audience find easy to follow. Complex plots introduce a new line of causality that exists over and above the characters. According to Aristotle, this added complexity is due to the addition of a ‘reversal’ and a ‘recognition’ to the simple plot. The reversal occurs when there is an unexpected action or event that runs counter to a character's situation and the spectator's expectations. It is often caused by an event which leads to significant and sudden consequences. The recognition is the moment when the protagonist becomes aware of the reversal, this provokes a transformation in their understanding of the events. These narrative strategies are usually at work in puzzle films. Linear chronology is usually altered in puzzle films. For Buckland, puzzle films tend to use a complex ordering of events that usually requires spectators’ active engagement and interpretation.

There are many examples of puzzle films that follow the narrative strategies explained before. In Martin Scorsese's *Shutter Island* (2010), for example, the discovery (revelation) that Teddy Daniels (Leonardo DiCaprio) is in fact Andrew Laeddis (a delusional patient) is what turns a noir-style investigation into both a puzzle film and a psychological exploration of the main character's mental state. Similarly, in *The Sixth Sense* (1999), directed by M. Night Shyamalan, spectators find out near the end of the movie that Dr. Crowe (Bruce Willis) has been dead from almost the beginning of the movie, a revelation that forces them to reinterpret most of what has happened in the film. A similar moment happens in *Fight Club* when the Narrator (and spectators) become aware of the fact that he and Tyler Durden are the same person. It marks both the reversal and the recognition. It also forces spectators to reinterpret the plot of the film. These examples of narrative reversals show how, as Buckland claims, puzzle films sabotage the audience's expectations at the same time as they increase the complexity of the story and the topics they are dealing with.

According to Edward Branigan's cognitive model of narration (1992) (cited in Buckland, p. 8), when analysing narration in a film we must take into account the different agents taking part in the process. These are the sender and receiver. However, there might be several senders and receivers, these include narrators, characters, and focalizers. The characters are seen by the spectator as agents who experience and act on the narrative level. In *Fight Club*, a particular narrative structure is found. The story is told by a first-person narrator who is also the main character, he is at the same time the storyteller and the focalizer. In addition to this, he guides the audience through his own feelings and emotions. Due to the turning point in which the audience discovers his disassociated and fragmented identity, the narrator is labelled as unreliable. Similar processes are at work in both *The Sixth*

Sense and *Shutter Island* (even if they do not use internal narrators). *The Sixth Sense* presents the protagonist and events in such a way that spectators are unaware of the main character's death until the final revelation (even if they have actually seen the character die on screen). Similarly, in *Shutter Island*, the audience see the protagonist as someone who is being betrayed or tricked while in fact, he is the one making everything up due to his mental condition.

The syuzhet (or plot) of a puzzle film tends to scramble and mix the temporal ordering of the events. When a film does not follow the traditional linear structure, the audience starts to rearrange the sequence of the events. This mental reconstruction is known as the fabula or story, through it, the spectator is creating a story in his or her mind that is going to evolve and change as the film progresses. In fact, some films deliberately seek for those incorrect inferences or assumptions in the spectator, such as *Fight Club*, *The Sixth Sense* and *Shutter Island*, therefore the three of them are puzzle films. This is also due to their respective final revelations plus their events out of order or without context. Consequently, the audience needs to reconstruct the fabula piecing together all the information in order to get the true sequence of events.

Puzzle films are usually filled with misleading clues. Spectators are led to draw false assumptions when watching *The Sixth Sense*, even though it is clear in subsequent viewing that Cole is the only one who is able to talk to Malcolm and that the movie never shows Malcolm reactions to anyone who is not Cole. In the case of *Shutter Island*, the film shows Teddy's perspective making the audience believe Teddy's delusional view of events as reality, in spite of certain incongruences regarding the investigation, the weird behaviour of some members of the staff and Teddy's mental instability. A similar process is at work in *Fight Club*, since the film

makes us believe that Tyler and the Narrator are two different people. This hidden information mirrors the culture around capitalism and consumerism, covering the truth about people's identities and roles in society, as will be explored in detail in the analysis of the film.

3. *FIGHT CLUB*

3.1. Fabula and syuzhet in *Fight Club*

Driven by The Dust Brothers's propulsive opening track, *Fight Club* kicks off with striking close-ups of human neurons and sweat glands. The constantly moving camera seems to be travelling through somebody's brain, already hinting at the movie's exploration of the human mind. Exiting from the forehead, the movement follows the shape of the face starting a path in the top part of the gun which is pointing directly into a character's mouth. This character is soon revealed to be the movie's internal narrator. His opening line, as a narrator, is "people are always asking me if I know Tyler Durden." Then, we hear an unnamed character, the one who is holding the gun inside the narrator's mouth, saying "Three minutes. This is it. Ground zero. Would you like to say a few words to mark the occasion?." The one with the gun in the mouth is not able to answer properly to the unnamed character (figure 1), he expresses the reason internally: "With a gun barrel between your teeth, you speak only in vowels."



Figure 1: The unnamed narrator being pointed by a gun.

After that, the narrator answers to the unnamed character and resumes his internal monologue: "for a second I totally forget about Tyler's whole controlled demolition thing and I wonder how clean this gun is." Since this moment, the audience has been given the first clue of what is happening. The unnamed character shows his excitement: "It is getting exciting now." The narrator in his internal monologue introduces another key topic in the film: toxic love: "that old thing, that you always hurt the one you love. Well, it works both ways." It is now when the narrator tells the audience about the demolition plan, the Project Mayhem. It is worth mentioning that this name encapsulates the goal that the project has. The project's goal is to dismantle consumer culture through destruction and chaos. As the narrator speaks, the camera glides through floors and buildings, revealing the planted bombs and visually reinforcing his words. Eventually, the shot returns to the room where the characters are. At this moment, the narrator looks at the unnamed character holding the gun and states, "I know this, because Tyler knows this."

The unnamed character is holding the gun, and he looks at a watch to see how much time is left: "two and a half, thank you for everything we have accomplished." As shown 2 only the objects are seen in the shot, these objects provide him an upper position of control over the other character. The clock represents his control over the countdown and the gun his empowered position in the scene. At this moment, the audience does not know who he is thanking or why he is using the pronoun "we." The narrator resumes one more time his internal monologue: "and suddenly I realised that all of this, the gun, the bombs, the revolution, has got something to do with a girl named Marla Singer."



Figure 2: Shot focusing on Tyler holding the watch and the gun.

Suddenly the narrator's head followed by the camera moves to the right and appears being hugged by Bob (who we still do not know). This shift regarding the story line is because the film brings the audience back through a flashback. We soon know that they are in a support group for men with testicular (symbol of masculinity) cancer, the audience again knows this due to the narrator's internal monologue. The camera focuses on a text that appears in the room that reads "remaining men together." In that support group, men are trying to help each other through sharing common suffering. They appear in pairs hugging each other and crying at the same time. Bob reiterates that they are still men and the unnamed narrator agrees. The motif of masculinity is now introduced in the film, men reiterating their masculinity and keeping their label of 'men'. The narrator is explaining Bob's situation and providing context when Bob tells the protagonist: "okey, you cry now." The narrator interrupts the flow of the story again and says: "No wait, back up, let me start earlier", referring directly to the audience even looking right to the camera. The narrator addresses straight to the audience with his dialogue and his sight since he is a direct internal narrator. At the same time as he does it, he also starts a second flashback within the previous flashback.

In the second flashback he appears awake in bed. He resumes his internal monologue and this time he is explaining his personal situation. He states his problems with sleep: "with insomnia nothing is real, everything is far away, everything is a copy of a copy of a copy." This is accompanied by shots of himself with a clear lack of sleep (figure 3) struggling in his office to remain awake and conscious of what is real and what is not. A camera movement guides the audience through the character's bin which is full of junk food wrappers and Starbucks coffee (symbols of consumerism), which points at his unhealthy diet. His boss comes to talk to him but his face remains offscreen, since the narrator is focused on his boss's tie, which according to him, signals that it is Tuesday. This suggests the character's monotonous life and his inability to distinguish one day from the next. At the same time all this happens, the narrator is introducing some of the topics that will come relevant throughout the movie later on, these are: power of corporations, capitalism and reality itself, as he puts it "nothing is real."



Figure 3: Jack with a clear lack of sleeping.

The protagonist has presented himself and although we still do not know what happens before the first scene, the film will eventually let the audience know it. From this moment on, the movie follows the chronological structure. Two hours and nine

minutes into the movie, the syuzhet takes us back to the opening scene and we see the unnamed narrator (now the audience knows he is called Jack) with the gun in his mouth again. Tyler says: "three minutes. This is it. The beginning. Ground zero." The narrator tells spectators: "I think this is about where we came in," highlighting that this is the way in which the movie and the syuzhet started. When Tyler asks Jack to say something he answers: "I still can't think of anything." The use of the word "still" is creating a connection between the beginning and the end. The film has been clearly playing with the chronology through the uses of flashbacks, as the narrator says: "flashback humour."

In the moment in which Jack is pushed against the window, he gazes at a bus (figure 4) and although it is difficult to be sure of who is there, he already knows it. The audience sees this through Jack's perspective. A group of members of the club, now members of the project Mayhem, are taking Marla against her will to the building where Tyler and Jack are. Tyler is doing it in order to "tie up loose ends." Jack begs him to stop it and Tyler responds: "I'm not doing this. We are doing this. This is what we want." Jack states: "I don't want this." Consequently, Tyler affirms: "Right. Except you is meaningless now." The pronouns each of the characters chooses to use are key to understanding the whole situation. Tyler highlights that they are doing everything together, on the contrary Jack insists on the fact that the events are happening against his will. Tyler also focuses on the meaningless use of 'you', he defends that they are doing something bigger than themselves, he believes that they are about to liberate society from capitalism and consumerism.



Figure 4: Bus seen through Jack's sight.

The characters are struggling with their identity. They start accusing each other of being "a voice in my head." Jack tries to convince himself of his own reality and consequently of Tyler's fakeness. Tyler defends that Jack needs him. He also tells Jack to take responsibility for him because he is the one who created Tyler. The camera now focuses on Tyler while he takes pride in what he does. Jack reiterates his disagreement: "this is too much, I don't want this." Tyler throws the cigarette, he stands up angrily and starts: "What do you want?!, you wanna go back to the shit job? back to the fucking condo world watching sitcoms, fuck you, I won't do it!" Jack is babbling and Tyler resumes: "it's already done, shut up. 60 seconds." He sits down again, and he smokes another cigarette with the gun in his hand. Tyler rejects the monotonous life that capitalist society has trapped Jack in. The scene shows both characters sitting down but with differences regarding the power they have over the situation, as seen in figure 5. Tyler is in a higher position, and he is free to move and stand up whereas Jack is tied to the chair which also has wheels as the only way of movement. It is worth mentioning that based on the way they are sitting, Tyler radiates confidence while Jack presents weakness.



Figure 5: Jack and Tyler with position differences.

Jack is clearly desperately trying to think of something to solve the situation, he starts whispering: "I can figure this out, I can figure this out. This isn't even real. You're not real, that gun... That gun isn't even in your hand. The gun is in my hand." After saying this, the gun appears suddenly in Jack's hand (figure 6), although he is shaking, he is starting to be brave and taking action. The gun is a symbol of power. Jack is controlling his thoughts, for the first time he is thinking to get what he really wants. However, for Tyler this "doesn't change a thing." Jack starts pointing to his own head from below his chin. Tyler asks: "why do you wanna put a gun to your head." Jack answers: "not my head Tyler. Our head." The use of possessives is again interesting, Jack is trying to threaten Tyler. He stands up and when he gets near Jack he says: "where are you going with this Ikea boy?." The nickname is used to mock Jack for his consumerist attitude. Once he realizes that Jack is about to shoot himself, he tries to be softer and with a posture of open arms he states: "hey, it's you and me. Friends?." Jack stands up, he is empowered and showing confidence like never before in the rest of the film, he looks directly at Tyler and starts: "I want you to really listen to me. My eyes are open." At that moment, he puts the gun into his mouth and shoots without hesitation. A slow framed camera

movement accompanies the gunshot, which is followed by several quick shots and a background whistling noise. Jake's body falls back on the chair, ending up seated once again. He has blood all over his neck and the gun is in his hand. Tyler exhales smoke from his mouth and says: "what's that smell?." Right after this, he collapses on the floor and his body fades away.



Figure 6: Jack holding the gun.

Some members of the project Mayhem arrive in the room. They address Jack as "Mr. Durden" and "Sir." Other members arrive bringing Marla with them against her will. Jack orders the men to leave the room. Marla starts screaming at him but when she gets closer and sees how Jack is she immediately shows worry for him. Jack insists that everything is going to be okay and suddenly all the buildings blow up. The audience sees the explosions through the windows, as Marla and Jack do. The scene is accompanied by the song "Where is my mind?" by Pixies. Not only the title but the song itself encapsulates the emotional and thematic collapse that is happening in the scene. The camera gets closer to the characters little by little, and it also does a close shot when they are grabbing each other's hands. In the last image they are looking at each other while all the buildings in front of them have been demolished, as seen in figure 7. Finally, the project accomplishes its goal.



Figure 7: Jack and Marla looking at each other while holding their hands together.

In *Fight Club* we find that the events are presented in a very specific way. The syuzhet begins in media res, showing the climax of the film before presenting two flashbacks. After these distortions in the narrative line, the story continues following a chronological order. This nonlinear narrative structure is not unplanned, in fact, it follows a specific purpose. The use of flashbacks creates suspense by increasing the audience's expectations. The opening scene, which is at the same time the ending of the film, sets up the narrative structure and encourages questioning the order in which events are presented. This is highlighted by the narrator when he states: "this is about where we came in." This quote points out the circular nature of the plot.

Even though the ending is shown at the beginning, the film still hides key information that will be revealed throughout the movie. For example, the reasons and full context of the demolition plan remain unknown until the final moments. This leads the audience to reorganise the previous events seeking for a new and full understanding. In addition to this, this narrative structure also embodies the

narrator's mental state, he is lost, confused and disconnected from reality. These feelings are also part of the alienation the film criticizes.

The film is playing with the audience, as Elssasser states (2009), *Fight Club* is a film in which "it is the audience that is played games with" (p. 14). The narrative strategy that the film follows leads the audience to false assumptions, this also provokes a constant reorganization of the events. It is when the audience completes the fabula organisation that the whole movie is understood. Beyond its use of narrative manipulation, the film builds intrigue and suspense by withholding crucial information and raising questions throughout. Viewers are left wondering: What occurred before the opening scene? Who is Tyler? Who is Marla?

It is important to mention that the narrator is an unreliable first person narrator. His character is playing with us, he lies to the audience, but he does not do it on purpose: it is just a consequence of his mental state. He is not aware of his split-mind (and neither are spectators), he is alienated and trapped in capitalism. The opening scene is just a piece of the puzzle, but it is only going to be understood at the end of the movie. The film is constantly giving us information that the audience will have to reorganise once all the pieces of the puzzle are over the table.

The fact that we have an internal narrator who at the same time is the protagonist of the film gives strong subjectivity to the film. The audience is linked to the unnamed character not only visually but also psychologically. His way of narrating added to the flashbacks he presents shape our understanding of the plot, making us part of his dissociated perspective. Apart from the narrator he is also the focalizer, he provides the information he believes to be true. This creates in the audience a sense of trustworthiness that will eventually be betrayed. Everything is

seen through his point of view. Once we discover that it is a false perception of reality, we realize that he is an unreliable narrator. It is in that moment when the audience starts raising questions about what they know. In this way, the film is making the audience feel the same uncertainty and loss of control that the main character feels. *Fight Club* is a psychological exploration of the narrator's dissociative perception of his own split-identity, this is a response to the alienation he is imposed by the consumerism and capitalism values.

Throughout the film, subtle clues hint at the game the audience is unknowingly drawn into. While viewers are entertained by the film's events and sequences, they are also actively trying to make sense of the underlying logic. One of *Fight Club*'s core themes is the confusion and fragmentation of identity—and the audience, too, becomes entangled in the same delusion. This confusion of the identity comes from the alienated world that capitalism is creating. The audience struggles to recognise what is real and the true identity of the characters. The film is blurring the line between spectator and participant; it makes the audience part of this exploration regarding the psychological distortion.

Fight Club is a puzzle film that drowns the audience into its narrative game. The circular and fragmented narrative structure is combined by the presence of an unreliable narrator. This challenges the audience to raise questions regarding what they are watching and to do an active reconstruction of the events. By doing so, the movie turns the spectator into a participant.

The following section will connect the film's narrative structure to its central themes and ideological messages—specifically, the impact of capitalism and consumer culture on the male individual.

3.2. Paternal absence and alienation under capitalism

Fight Club deals with deep topics regarding not only the individual but also the society. The identity dissociation suffered by Jack, in which the audience is also involved, comes from the capitalism that is surrounding the society. This suggests that societal conditions are shaping the individual. In the film, we see how a man immersed in consumer culture gradually loses his sense of masculinity. This drives the protagonist to create an 'alter-ego' which is his own counterpart. It is done in order to create someone which embodies his repressed masculinity and feelings. These repressed emotions are the result that comes from the alienation caused by consumerism and capitalism. It is clear that Tyler embodies a completely different form of manliness compared to Jack.

The film is a direct critique of capitalism and consumerism; this is done through the scope of a man with identity dissociation and split masculinity. The protagonist of the film not only creates an alter-ego but also a fighting club. This club is only composed of men and at the beginning it is based on bare-knuckle fights. The most known rule of the club is "you do not talk about Fight Club" (one of the most iconic sentences from the film). There is a moment in which Tyler starts to give homework assignments for the members of the club. This is when instead of being only a club for fighting, it starts being centred on vandalism. The assignments and the club are little by little getting its members closer to an anarchist rebellion rather than just a bare-knuckle fighting club.

The film presents two different characters that portray two opposing models of masculinity. The narrator is the representation of passive and domesticated masculinity, he represses his own feelings, and he has no control at all over himself.

He suffers from insomnia and his monotonous daily life is marked by a corporate job that alienates him. He is also addicted to buying pieces of furniture. As he puts it, "that was not just a bunch of stuff that got destroyed; it was me." He bases his own identity on his pieces of furniture. This reflects that he is trapped within the consumer society. His only way of liberating from his monotonous routine is to go to support groups although he does not have any illness, it is the only way in which he can feel relief and get some sleep at night. His troubled identity starts to be hinted at when he uses different names for each of the support groups. The relief he experiences when attending these meetings, ends when Marla starts going to the meetings as well, she is also an "impostor", but her attitude and behaviour present her as a mentally unstable person. Marla makes the protagonist unable to get the same relief he used to feel. They will eventually divide their assistance to these support groups.

Jack appears getting plenty of fights due to his job, and suddenly he meets Tyler in one of these. Since the first moment Tyler appears in the film, it is clear that he is a confident man. He embodies a hyper-masculinity prototype. He is charismatic and dominant. He makes and sells soap made from stolen human fat. In his behaviour we also realize his hyper-sexuality, he gives his back to Jack but not to the flight attendant that is bending over one of the seats, in what, as seen from Jack's point of view, is made to look like a sex position (figure 8). He is an anti-authoritarian and radical opponent of the consumer system. When he meets with Jack in Lou's Tavern (future place for the club), he clearly shows his ideology with statements such as: "Why do we call it 'duvet'... we are consumers", "fuck your furniture", "stop being perfect, let's evolve." Eventually, he encourages Jack to hit him, when Jack does so, he gets even a greater emotional release than in the support groups. Tyler is trying

to get Jack into the same way of thinking and acting as him, he will do the same later in the film with the rest of the members of the Project Mayhem.



Figure 8: Tyler facing the flight attendant's back.

These characters are completely different. They have opposed personalities and ways of behaving in society, their ideologies and thoughts are also extremely distinct. In addition to this, their clothing and physical appearance have nothing to do with each other. Since the first scene in which Tyler appears, these differences can be perceived. They meet in the emergency seats in an airplane. Jack is wearing a corporate grey suit with a tie while Tyler is wearing a flashy red blazer and sunglasses. They talk about the oxygen during a plane accident. Jack thinks that it is for breathing but Tyler states that it is in order to make people feel high, so they accept their tragic fate. During the conversation, he also talks about explosives. It is not only what he says but also in the way it is said that he is seen as enigmatic and paranoid. The audience already knows about Jack, once we get to know Tyler, it can be seen that they are poles apart.

Their differences are not only in themselves but also in the events they are involved in. Right after the plane, Tyler drives away in a stolen sports red car. On the other hand, Jack is trying to recover his suitcase that has been intercepted because of an unusual vibration. The airport worker suggests that it may be due to a dildo, doubting Jack's masculinity. He finally goes back home without his suitcase. However, when he arrives, his flat and all the furniture inside it is on fire. Jack finds himself with no suitcase, no furniture and no house. In this moment, Jack realizes that what he used to consider his reality is, in fact, a fake one. This realisation is similar to the one the audience experiences when they become aware of the false version of the story they have been led to believe in.

Despite the clear differences between both characters, they share a key fact regarding the film and the plot itself. This is the absence of the father figure. Mike Chopra-Gant (2013) highlights the scene in which the characters start talking about their fathers. For Tyler his father was deficient in providing guidance, but Jack's father left when Jack was still six years old. "The father constructed by *Fight Club* is therefore physically absent and/ or hopelessly deficient as an inspirational role model for young men, incapable even of imagining a role for his sons beyond the restrictive and stultifying options of corporate careerism and familial reproduction: get educated, get a job, get married" (pp. 89-90). Tyler riding a bike inside the house is an example of the infantilization caused by this lack of father engagement (figure 9).



Figure 9: Tyler riding a bike inside the house.

Guy Corneau (cited in Chopra-Grant, 2013), states “the absence of fathers as a key source of the identity crises experienced by men” (p. 90). According to Corneau, the lack of paternal engagement deprives men of the role models they need when it comes to the formation of a stable identity. For Jack and Tyler, it also causes the rejection of other paternal figures. They talk several times throughout the film about who they would fight. Their answers to this question reflect this rejection. In the scene in which they first talk about their fathers (figure 10), Tyler states that he would fight his father. This honest conversation unfolds in the bathroom, a setting that reflects the growing trust and intimacy between them. Later on, the answers they keep giving during the film are related to paternalistic figures. The relationship between the answers and the paternal image is explained by Chopra-Gant (2013), ““Papa” Hemingway; William Shatner, best known for his role as Captain James T. Kirk in *Star Trek*, a powerful paternalistic authority figure within the diegetic world of the series and for its legions of fans; Gandhi, the father of the Indian nation; and Lincoln, the father of the Union” (pp. 90-91).



Figure 10: Jack and Tyler talking in the bathroom.

Apart from the influence of the paternalistic absence experienced by the characters in *Fight Club*, there is another key reason that explains the dissociative identity that Jack presents. As Frederic Jameson argues in "Postmodernism and Consumer Society" (1983), under postmodernism, people cannot maintain a stable identity. As a result of consumerist culture, media saturation, and constant technological change, the individual experiences life in a fragmented way, leading to a loss of a stable sense of self. Jack's split identity powerfully illustrates Jameson's concept. Ultimately, it is the postmodern capitalist and consumerist society that drives Jack's fractured identity and dissociative state.

Jameson also suggests that in a postmodernist society, identity is increasingly shaped by not only consumer habits but also superficial appearances. The way in which Jack's life revolves around IKEA furniture embodies this idea. Jack's identity is split but it is also based on consumer goods lacking internal values. In addition to this, he is struggling to maintain masculinity, which is also another point dealt by Jameson. The club is a parody of the supposed 'authentic masculinity', directly connected to an extreme and wide use violence. The club at the same time reflects

Jameson's idea of a hyperreal version of male bonding as a result of the postmodernist society. Capitalism and consumerism create an alienated world that leads to the confusion of identity.

One key scene also mentioned by Chopra-Grant (2013) is the one in which the characters are on a bus. They see an advertisement of underwear for men from the Gucci brand. The image shows two images of the supposed ideal masculinity (figure 11), the one that follows the established masculine beauty canons. The two characters reflect and mock that image, "Is that what a man looks like?." In this case, they are rejecting both the idea of masculinity enforced by the dominant culture, and the image that the consumer culture imposes on society.



Figure 11: Gucci's underwear advertisement.

It's important to note that what Tyler offers the members and followers of Project Mayhem is essentially a doctrine. They become part of a cult-like group, with Tyler providing an alternative to escape the alienation imposed by the dominant culture. However, this alternative is also an indoctrination. Tyler is offering a liberation from the alienation by indoctrinating them into an anti-system movement, involving them in terrorist's actions. If the only way to escape the alienation caused

by capitalism and dominant culture is taking part in a sectarian group in which the individual is going to be indoctrinated, is there any pure way or option to achieve real freedom? Is belonging to the club or the project a liberation or is in fact just another alienation of the individual?

4. CONCLUSION

This essay has analysed David Fincher's *Fight Club* as an example of a puzzle film. As such, the narrative structure of the film differs from what is usually regarded as the classical Hollywood narrative structure because, among other narrative strategies, of the use of a narrative reversal and a character's and spectators' moment of recognition. The syuzhet of the film arranges fabula events in a specific manner in order to "play a game" with spectators. It also hides key pieces of information from spectators, such as the fact that the characters played by Edward Norton and Brad Pitt are, in fact, two sides of the same character. The temporal structure of the syuzhet also contributes to this, since it starts with what is actually the ending of the fabula and then includes two flashbacks to explain how the protagonist got to the situation where we find him at the end. As a result, from the beginning of the film, spectators start to ask themselves multiple questions, some of which are answered by the movie's narrator. However, the information that is given by the internal narrator is eventually revealed to be unreliable, just like himself. Through this process, *Fight Club* engages spectators' attention and involves them in the fake reality of the narrator.

The false assumptions, the unreliable narrator and the distorted temporality of the film are features that can be related to one of the main themes of the film: its critique of consumerism and capitalism. Consumer and capitalist discourses sell a specific idea of what it means to be an individual in postmodern society, a discourse that, in the film, is presented as misleading and alienating, mirroring the narrative structure of the film itself. In order to survive in a world that dehumanises and emasculates him, Jack, the protagonist and narrator, creates an alter-ego that

embodies aspects contrary to his repressed manliness and passive masculinity. In addition to this, as was argued in the last part of the analysis of the film, the absence of a father figure creates a rejection of other paternal figures in both characters, Jack and his mental creation, Tyler. This essay has argued that the main character's dissociative identity and split self are consequences of the postmodern alienation caused by capitalism and the dominant culture. The anti-system movement (project Mayhem), created by Tyler, seeks for the destruction of consumerism and capitalism structures that are seen as oppressing and dehumanizing society. And yet, as argued in the final part, Tyler's doctrine can be seen as another way of indoctrination not that different from that of capitalism, casting doubts about the possibility of a society that does not result in the alienation of its subjects.

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